Workshop Exercise: Argument Extraction: Algorithmic Decision-Making

Selection from:

Rubel, Alan, Clinton Castro, and Adam Pham (2020). "Algorithms, Agency, and Respect for Persons". *Social Theory and Practice* 46(3):547-572.

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An argument concerning algorithmic decision-making.

One important criticism of algorithmic systems is that they lack transparency. Such systems can be opaque because they are complex, protected by patent or trade secret, or deliberately obscure (Pasquale 2016). But it is worth asking why transparency is important. Transparency may be important for instrumental purposes, and in the case of public use of algorithms, transparency may be important for accountability (Powles 2017).[17] Our view is that transparency is also integral for respecting agency.[18] To see why, consider the following.

As we argued in section 2, agents are autonomous only if they are able to incorporate their values into important facets of their lives. Respecting an agent's autonomy requires that one not deny her what she needs to incorporate her values into important facets of her life. So, it is a failure of respect for autonomy to prevent agents from exercising their autonomy without good reason.

Incorporating one's values into important facets of one's life requires that one have access to relevant information. This is on account of two distinct aspects of agency (for a similar division of aspects of our agency and discussion, see Smith 2013). One aspect of agency is the ability to take actions that realize one's values. Call this 'practical agency'. So, for example, if it's important to a person to build a successful career, then it is important for her to understand how her organization functions, how to get to work, how to actually perform tasks assigned, and so forth. And if that person's supervisor fails to make available information that is relevant to her job performance, the supervisor fails to respect the person's practical agency because doing so creates a barrier to the employee incorporating her values into an important facet of her life.

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[. . .]

Since autonomy requires having information relevant to one's life, respecting autonomy requires not denying agents that information. Algorithmic decision systems are often not built to be transparent (Pasquale 2016).

[. . .]

[This passage adds a bit of clarification about autonomy, if you need it.]

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Autonomy includes at least the ability to self-govern. The ability to self-govern includes the ability to develop one's own conception of value and sense of what matters, to [choose] the values that will guide one's actions and decisions, and to make important decisions about one's life according to those values where one sees fit (Hill 1989, Brock 1999).

Background / Set up

State the argument in outline

Explain Any Rationales for the Premises

Evaluate the argument